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COL-310508

Madwoman's Garden

Lady in the Garden: Ah, a perfect blossom. So delicate, so beautiful.

Lady in the Garden: Oh, my sweet little creation! Whatever am I to do with you now?

Flutterpage and Lamplighter crouch behind a hedge, watching as the lone figure plucks a flower and brings it to her nose.

Were it not for the dark red stains on her clothing, she might appear no different from any other gardener.

Flutterpage: So this is the so-called madwoman that critter was talkin' about? She looks plenty nice to me.

Lamplighter: We can't be too sure about that. There are loads of stories about this lady. Rumor has it she's ...

Lamplighter bites her tongue. The Lady in the Garden suddenly flings the delicate flowers to the ground in a fit of rage.

Lady in the Garden: Destroy you all, naturally! Rip! Shred! Destroy!

Lady in the Garden: How about this! Ahahahahaha!

She crushes the flowers beneath her heels, stomping maniacally, over and over, until the once-blooming flowers are reduced to mulch.

Flutterpage: Oh. Right then, spoke a bit too soon, eh?

The girls glance at each other, both taking cautious steps back, but it appears to be too little, too late.

Lady in the Garden: Who's there?!

In the blink of an eye, the Lady in the Garden is standing before them. The girls gasp, frozen on the spot.

Lady in the Garden: Again! Again! You noisy insolent invaders think you can trespass in my garden again?!

Flutterpage: Eh?

A word in the madwoman's rant stands out to Flutterpage.

Flutterpage: Wait, you mean ... Are you the one who planted all these flowers, Miss?

Lady in the Garden: Me? Yes, of course! I raised them, every petal, every stem, each more beautiful than the last.

Lady in the Garden: And then I pluck 'em! Smash 'em! Feast on 'em! Cast 'em into the mud! Hahaha!

Despite flinching at the lady's outburst, Flutterpage's curiosity wins out, and she presses forward with her questioning.

Flutterpage: I don't get it. Bit strange, innit? Why grow all these flowers only to smash 'em up? Ain't you fond of 'em?

Lady in the Garden: Me? Fond of flowers? No!

Lady in the Garden: They are nasty, disgusting things.

Flutterpage: But why bother growin' 'em if you hate 'em so much?

Lady in the Garden: I simply can't live without 'em.

Lady in the Garden: Their scents, their lovely vibrant hues. I simply can't live without 'em.

The Lady in the Garden bends down and snaps off a branch yet to bloom, tracing its delicate outline with her fingers.

Lady in the Garden: Ah, yes, this one. This will bloom into a horror that plagues me day and night.

Her movements are delicate, yet the veins swelling on her trembling hands betray the violent urges she struggles to suppress.

Flutterpage: You need 'em, but you hate 'em. No wonder you're in such a state.

Flutterpage: But you've gotta admit, these flowers are certainly beautiful.

Flutterpage: If you didn't care for 'em, not even a little, I don't think they'd be so beautiful.

Lady in the Garden: Beautiful? You really think they're beautiful?

Flutterpage: Yes! They're bleedin' gorgeous!

Lady in the Garden: Really? Is that what you see? Beauty?

Lady in the Garden: That's marvelous. Truly marvelous.

In a trance, the Lady in the Garden rises, murmuring under her breath as she drifts into the blossoms.

Flutterpage: Where're you off to?

She remains silent as the twig slips through her fingertips, falling softly on the petals beneath.

The Lady in the Garden fades into the sea of flowers beyond them.

Lamplighter: Look, it's those fireflies again!

Lamplighter's voice snaps Flutterpage out of her daze. Her eyes catch the soft glow rising from the fallen branch, similar to the lights they have seen before.

Flutterpage: Wow! Another piece of me name, the third letter.

Lamplighter: Honestly, I was prepared for the worst this time, but it turned out a lot easier than I'd imagined.

Flutterpage: So, turns out the flowers were what she held dear. Hmm.

Lamplighter: What's the matter? You look a little down.

Flutterpage: Reckon it'll flower again someday?

Lamplighter: Huh?

Flutterpage: The twig she dropped. Once we're done, I could stick it in a vase, see if it blossoms again, all pretty-like.

Flutterpage picks up the twig left behind by the Lady in the Garden and places it in her pocket.

# [English text unavailable]

COL-310513

Lamplighter: Watch out!

Lamplighter: It's the Bananach! It's here!

Flutterpage: Lamplighter, leg it—quick!

And then ...

Amid the endless darkness, something briefly flickers before her eyes.

Flutterpage: What? That's ...

Lamplighter: Don't come any closer, you beast of foulest darkness!

Flutterpage barely registers what's happening before Lamplighter raises her stick and strikes the earth with incredible force.

A brilliant light bursts forth, banishing the darkness for a fleeting moment. Lamplighter seizes Flutterpage by the wrist.

Lamplighter: Let's get out of here!

Flutterpage: No. I can't!

Lamplighter: What are you talking about?! That thing'll be the end of you!

Flutterpage: I saw it! My name! It's there.

Flutterpage: In the depths of the dark! It's on the Bananach!

Lamplighter: Wait, no! Flutterpage?!

Lamplighter's call goes unanswered, as Flutterpage's trailing dress vanishes into the shadows.

# [English text unavailable]

COL-310514

Flutterpage: Hey! Where are ya?!

Her voice is consumed by the darkness, vanishing completely.

Flutterpage: No answer. Not that I thought there'd be.

Being a child full of questions, darkness is a pain. It always remains silent, as if it's saying, "Don't ask me nothing."

Flutterpage: But I'll find ya.

She moves across the grass, at first making every effort to step softly.

But the silence around her is unnerving. Even the faintest crackle of crushed leaves beneath her shoes feels harsh and intrusive.

Flutterpage: Right then, if that's the way it's gonna be.

And so, she steps confidently into the enveloping darkness.

Flutterpage: ...!

Something is indeed lurking in the dark as expected, bursting to life like an erupting spring.

Crawling and seething, shadows spill out from every corner of the darkness.

Flutterpage: They, they're coming! I ... What?!

The slimy darkness fills Flutterpage's mouth and nose before she can resist. Even her sight is turning dark.

She can't breathe, and all is black.

Flutterpage: *coughs*

Her consciousness begins to slip away.

Flutterpage: *coughs*

All around her, the darkness begins to ripple, and faint mocking laughter echoes from every side.

Voice in the Dark: Look at her, poor child.

Voice in the Dark: Why would you try so hard? What for?

Voice in the Dark: You look ridiculous. You surely know that, don't you?

Flutterpage: What? You're ...

Voice in the Dark: Give it up. You don't need that name of yours as much as you think. It's nothing more than a title.

Voice in the Dark: Just leave it to us. This is what you wanted, isn't it?

Flutterpage: Give ... up ...?

Indeed, someone provides her with the answer—the simplest solution.

All she needs to do is give up, then she will no longer have to endure this suffering.

And why shouldn't she?

!+*?%&#: I ...

The once again nameless girl drifts into a vast, unyielding void.

The warm darkness promises her every answer she seeks. But she has no need to ask anymore.

But just as her last bit of sense fades away, a beam of light breaks through.

!+*?%&#: ...?!

Flutterpage: No.

Flutterpage: This isn't the answer I want! I know what you're up to, and I won't fall for it this time!

Flutterpage: Look out, I'm coming in!

Flutterpage jumps into the depths of the dark, where the voice had come from.

And then, she crashes straight to the ground.

Flutterpage: Oof!

Flutterpage: ...

She scrambles to her feet, paying no mind to the dirt and grass clinging to her clothes, and stares into the empty nothingness.

Then, she laughs.

Flutterpage: Haha. Hahaha!

Flutterpage: I've got it. I knew I was right about you all along! Bananach, you—you ain't even got a body! Yer just an empty shell!

Voice in the Dark: ...

The whispers trail into silence.

The darkness thins out, revealing a sea of stars. The night sky is lit by fireflies.

Flutterpage: Gotcha! The sixth letter.

Flutterpage: What a riot, really. I was frightened of that thing for ages, and it weren't nothing!

Lamplighter: Flutterpage! Are you alright?

Flutterpage: I'm standin' here, ain't I? Right as rain.

Flutterpage: Turns out, it was just me frightenin' myself all along. The Bananach mumbles a lot of odd things, but that's as far as it goes.

Flutterpage: Whatever mumbles on about from now on, I won't let it bother me no more.

Lamplighter's eyes grow wide, and after a short pause, she finally speaks.

Lamplighter: You're amazing, Flutterpage. I knew you had it in you.

Lamplighter: Hang on! Now's not the time for celebrating!

Lamplighter: We've only found six letters, but the Administrator said there were seven altogether!

Lamplighter: That means we're still missing one more, and we have no idea where those fairies hid it! We've gotta find it—fast!

Despite Lamplighter's mounting anxiety, Flutterpage looks strangely relaxed.

Flutterpage: The fireflies ain't flyin' no more.

Lamplighter: Huh?

Flutterpage: Look.

Lamplighter: They've sunk down to the bottom of the pouch.

Lamplighter: What's going on? Shouldn't they be able to sense where their friends are?

Lamplighter: Now we're in for it. Dawn's almost breaking! M-Maybe we should hurry back and ask the Administrator?

Flutterpage: I think I know the answer.

Lamplighter stops in her tracks, a look of confusion settling on her face as she glances at Flutterpage.

Lamplighter: What do you mean by "answer"?

Flutterpage: The answer to everything.